

How to maintain your reality when leadership makes you question your own performance — Action Checklist

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RECOGNIZE THE TACTICS

- ☐ **Recognize Your Manager's Patterns:** Review all six reality-distortion tactics—timeline distortion, blame inversion, credit theft, outcome reframing, memory denial, and emotional attribution—and identify which ones appear most frequently in your manager's behavior, because naming the pattern gives you the vocabulary to see what's actually happening.
- ☐ **Complete the Diagnostic Exercise:** Write down the last three to five conversations where you left feeling off-balance, confused, or like you'd done something wrong, then match each conversation to the specific pattern it represents, because this exercise builds your personal playbook for recognizing manipulation in real time.
- ☐ **Notice Your Physical Warning Signs:** Pay attention to when your stomach knots, chest tightens, or you feel generally off-balance after speaking with your manager, because your nervous system often recognizes manipulation hours before your rational mind can articulate what happened.
- ☐ **Separate Feedback from Distortion:** When you receive criticism, ask whether it references specific events with evidence or relies on vague characterizations of your behavior, because legitimate feedback has substance while distortion tactics hide behind generality and emotional pressure.

DOCUMENT YOUR REALITY

- ☐ **Timestamp Your Records Immediately:** After any significant conversation with your manager, write down the date, time, attendees, and key points discussed while your memory is fresh, because your documented record becomes your anchor when someone later rewrites what actually happened.
 - ☐ **Log Specific Details Over Feelings:** When documenting conversations, record exactly what was said using direct quotes or paraphrases rather than your emotional interpretation of the exchange, because factual anchors are harder to dispute than subjective impressions.
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- **Build an Independent Archive:** Keep your documentation in a location your manager cannot access—such as a personal email account or encrypted notes app—rather than work systems they control, because an archive only holds value if no one else can alter or delete it.
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- **Record What Was Said Not What's Claimed:** When your manager claims something different happened than you remember, document both versions with the date you first heard each one, because this creates a verifiable record of when discrepancies emerged and who introduced them.

RESPOND WITH STRATEGY

- **Check Your State Before Responding:** Before you push back on any distortion, pause to assess whether you're in a calm, regulated state or running on adrenaline, because reacting from survival mode often provides the evidence they need to label you as emotional or unstable.
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- **Prepare Specific Counter-Phrases:** Develop brief, factual responses for your manager's most common patterns—such as "I have documentation showing I raised this concern on March 3rd" for timeline distortion—because having ready responses prevents you from being caught off-guard and floundering in the moment.
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- **Respond to the Pattern Not the Detail:** When your manager distorts something, name the pattern without getting drawn into debating the specific detail they're distorting, because countering the tactic itself is harder for them to deflect than arguing about individual facts.
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- **Anchor to Your Documented Self:** After any destabilizing interaction, return to your records and read what you wrote immediately after the original conversation, because seeing your own timestamped account reminds you that your perception was clear and coherent before your memory got overwritten.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.